

AETHERA 2026

Official Rulebook

SESE, IIT (ISM) Dhanbad | WWF, Knowledge Partner | Concetto '26

1. Overview

Aethera is a national sustainability case competition organised by the Society of Environmental Science & Engineering (SESE), IIT (ISM) Dhanbad, as part of Concetto '26. Teams from IITs, NITs and institutes across the country work live industry problems in carbon accounting, BRSR disclosure and EPR compliance, diagnose them, build costed solutions, and defend them before an expert panel.

2. Eligibility & Team Composition

- Open to all undergraduate and postgraduate students, from any discipline and any recognised institute in India.
- Teams must have a minimum of 1 and a maximum of 3 members.
- Cross-institute teams are not permitted; all members of a team must be from the same institute.
- Each participant may be part of only one team.

3. Competition Format

Aethera runs across three rounds:

- Round 1, Online Screening Test: conducted on Unstop. Tests foundational and applied knowledge of sustainability, consulting and case fundamentals. Auto-evaluated. Approximately 150 teams advance.
- Round 2, Case Submission: shortlisted teams receive a live industry case and submit a 10-slide response deck. Blind-scored by the review panel against a published rubric. Top 10 teams advance to the finale.
- Round 3, The Boardroom (Finale): the top 10 teams pitch live before the panel, followed by a sealed 'Curveball' round in which teams must rework their solution against a new constraint revealed on the spot. Held online via video conference on Sunday, 11 October, and live-streamed.

4. Key Dates

Registrations open	Round 1 (online)	Round 2 (case)	Finale
17 September	30 September	1 – 6 October	11 October

5. Evaluation & Review Panel

Round 1 is auto-evaluated. Round 2 and the finale are judged by a named review panel comprising:

- Two departmental faculty members
- Members of the SESE core team
- A representative of the partner organisation, where the case is drawn from their business problem

Round 2 submissions are scored blind, without team names visible to the panel, against a rubric published to participants before submission. The panel's decision at every stage is final.

6. Prize Structure

Total prize pool: Rs. 60,000 (cash and partner vouchers combined).

Position	Cash	Vouchers	Total
Winner	Rs. 20,000	Rs. 10,000	Rs. 30,000
1st Runner-up	Rs. 12,000	Rs. 6,000	Rs. 18,000

2nd Runner-up	Rs. 8,000	Rs. 4,000	Rs. 12,000
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7. Submission Guidelines

- Round 2 submissions must be a maximum of 10 slides, submitted as a single PDF, via the link and deadline shared after Round 1 results.
- Late submissions will not be evaluated, regardless of the reason for delay.
- Teams may not alter their composition once Round 1 registration closes.

8. Code of Conduct

- All submissions must be original work by the registered team. Plagiarism in any round leads to immediate disqualification.
- Any attempt to contact panel members to influence scoring will result in disqualification.
- Participants are expected to maintain professional conduct through all rounds, including the live finale.

9. Contact

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